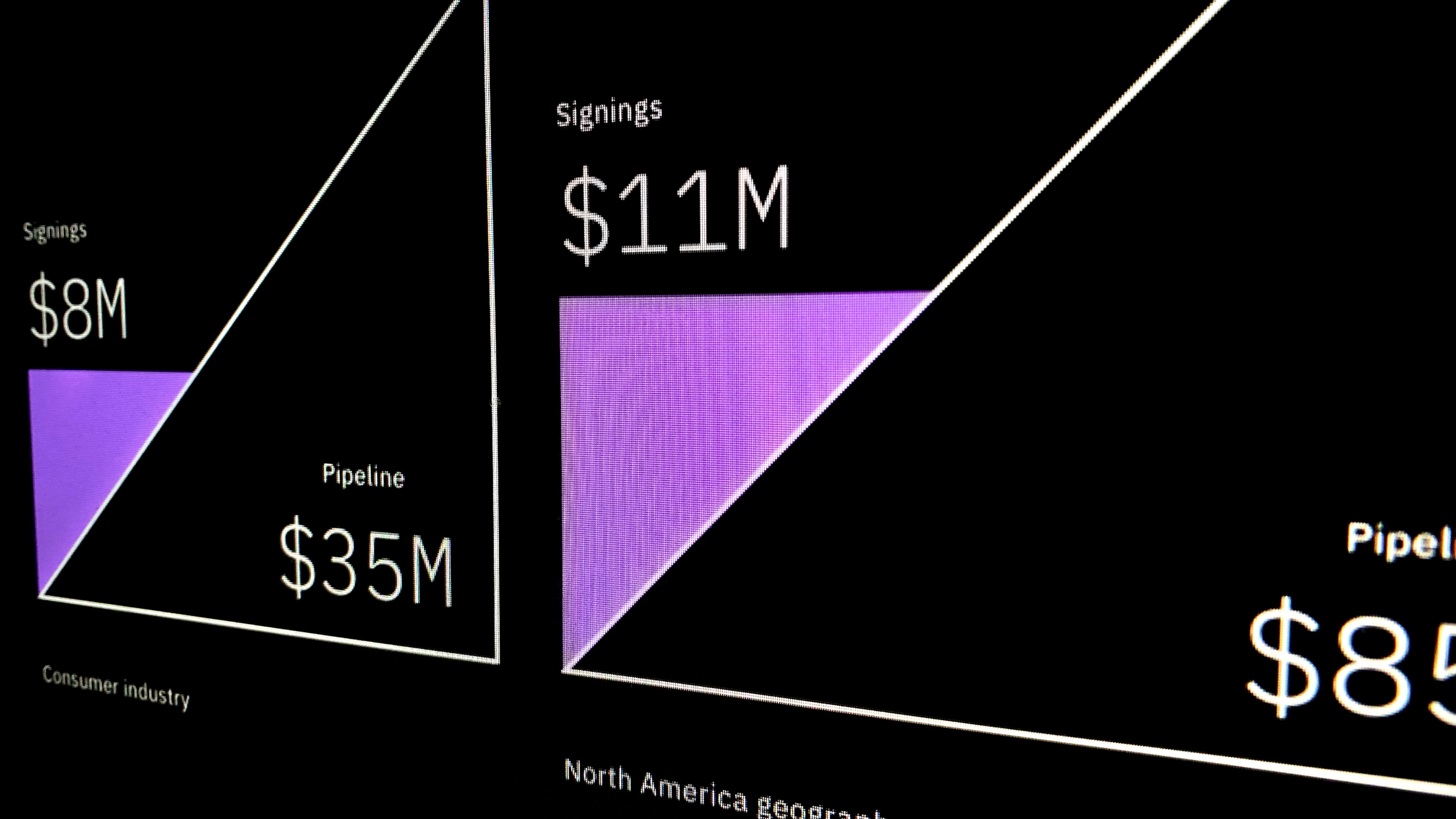

Signings
$8M
Pipeline
$35M
Consumer industry
Signings
$11M
Pipel
$85
North America

Quarter in Review

A digital report for service offering leaders that provides visibility into their offering's readiness, financial performance, and consultant usage.

GOAL

The report aimed to provide service offering leaders an adoptable experience that would motivate them to improve the quality of their offering.

CLIENT AND SCOPE

The internal client for this project was IBM Services Offering Management and lasted for 6 weeks in early 2020.

ROLE

I co-designed this report with another UX designer and my biggest contribution to the project was its user interface and data visualizations.

OUTCOMES

Within two quarters, the report scaled from 1 offering to 28 offerings and received high engagement with offering teams.

How might we design a better way for offering leaders to manage their offering's lifecycle?

My team supported the team who developed IBM Service's offerings
I became involved with this project because my design organization partnered with the IBM Services Offering Management team. They were a team of leaders, consultants and subject matter experts who focused on changing the way IBM Services sold, solutioned, and delivered service offerings.

Offering teams lacked reliable and accessible data for continual improvement
Most of the Offering Management team's energy focused on the creation of service offerings through a facilitated program. Once a team created an offering in the program, the offering's leader was accountable for its growth and improvement over time. However, leaders and their teams struggled. Contributing to their pain was the lack of accessible quantitative and qualitative feedback to make evidence-based decisions.

Missing, fragmented, or conflicting data bred mistrust among offering teams
Data existed, but was fragmented and hard to consume. For example, downloads on offering content were available, but were stored across several platforms. This made piecing together a story on an offering's usage painstaking.

Also, Offering Management distributed spreadsheets of financial performance data over e-mail. And so did other parts of the organization, often with charge codes collated differently. Other times, e-mails got lost in a sea of noise.

Overall, IBM's complex Intranet and organization failed offering leaders in their attempts to find reliable information. These conditions bred mistrust and offering leaders were often skeptical about the validity of what was shown to them.

Organizational barriers kept offering leaders unskilled and poorly incentivized
Perhaps more problematic was the varying skills and time Offering Leaders had to invest in their offering.

Skills
Offering Leaders came from engineering and sales roles and tended to have blind spots in their ability to manage an offering. At times they lacked skills to form proper insights from data and address gaps.

Time
While responsible for the performance of their practice, they weren't responsible for performance of their offering. Dedicating time to offering management activities did not impact their bottom line and fell toward the end of their priorities.

The report's vision was to provide vital information and learn fast from its release
IBM Services Offering Management needed my team's help to overcome these challenges because without consistent care, the offerings would become obsolete over time.

We believed that designing a quarterly report with the right information, with the right density, through the right channel would help offering leaders maintain and evolve high quality offerings.

Last, this design intervention fit into a bigger play in our design organization. A thematic focus for our team was to help offering teams maintain the lifecycle of their offerings. This opportunity was a way for us to swiftly put out an experiment into the world and learn from it.

Offering Content Report user flow

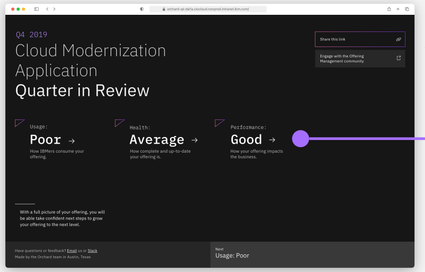
An offering leader receives an email from IBM Services Offering Management inviting them to check out their offering's Quarter in Review report.

Upon arriving at the Home view, they can see their Offering's score across three dimensions: usage, health and performance.

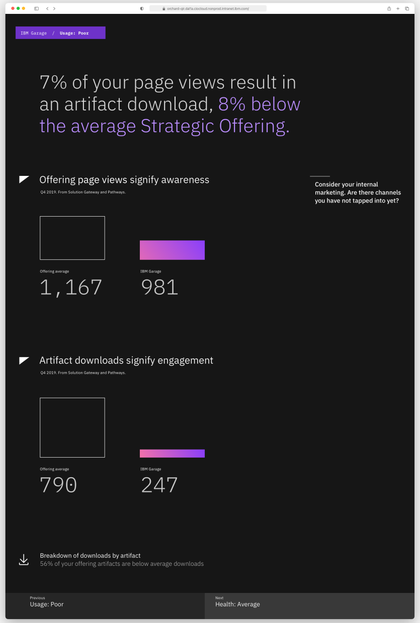
As they move through each dimension, they are prompted to explore the data in more detail and provided next best actions they can take to improve each dimension.

Upon returning back to the Home view, they can share the report with their team.

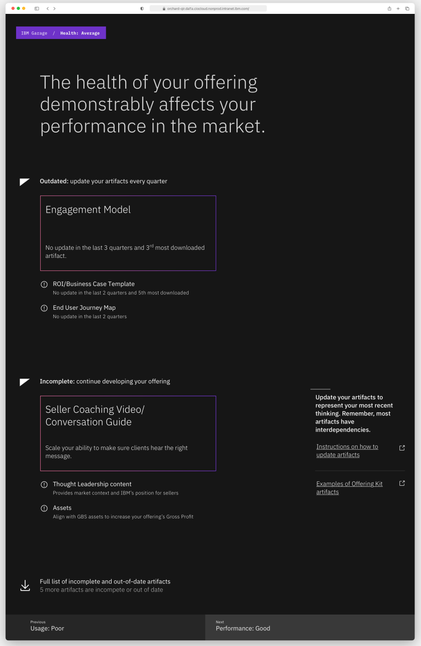
Home



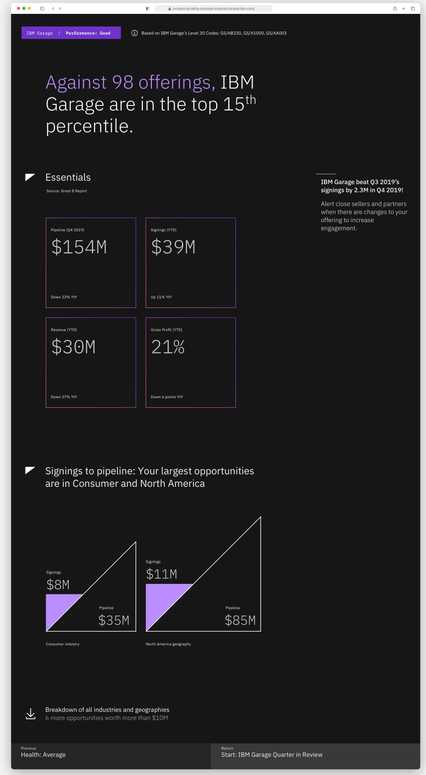
Usage



Health



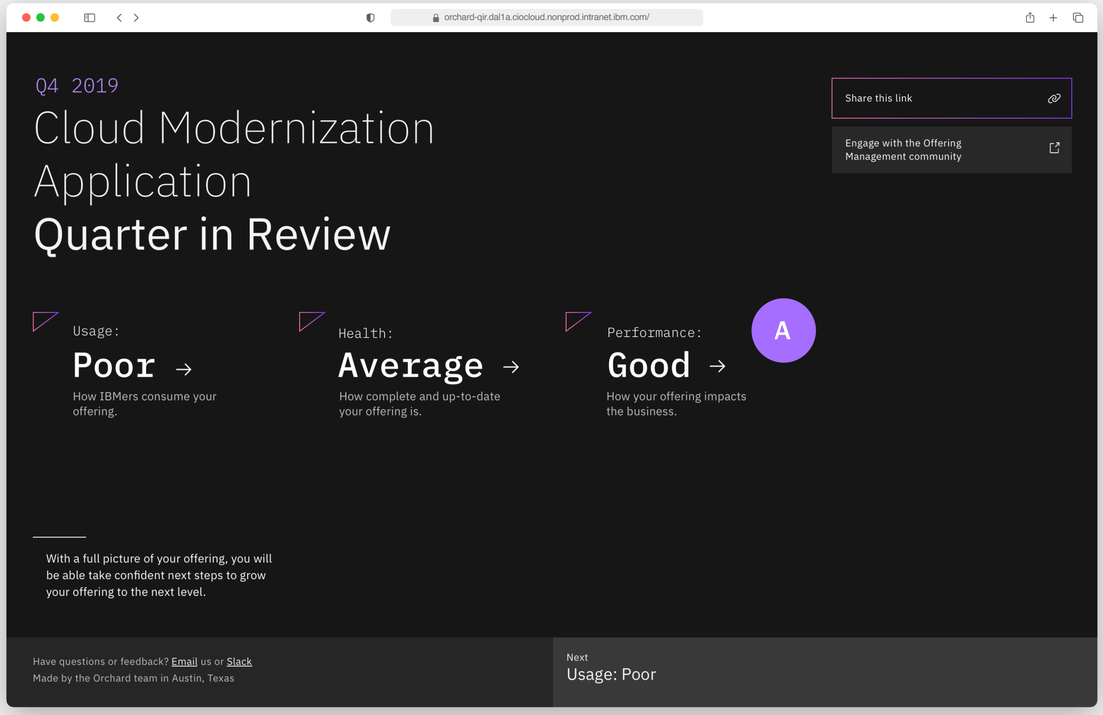
Performance



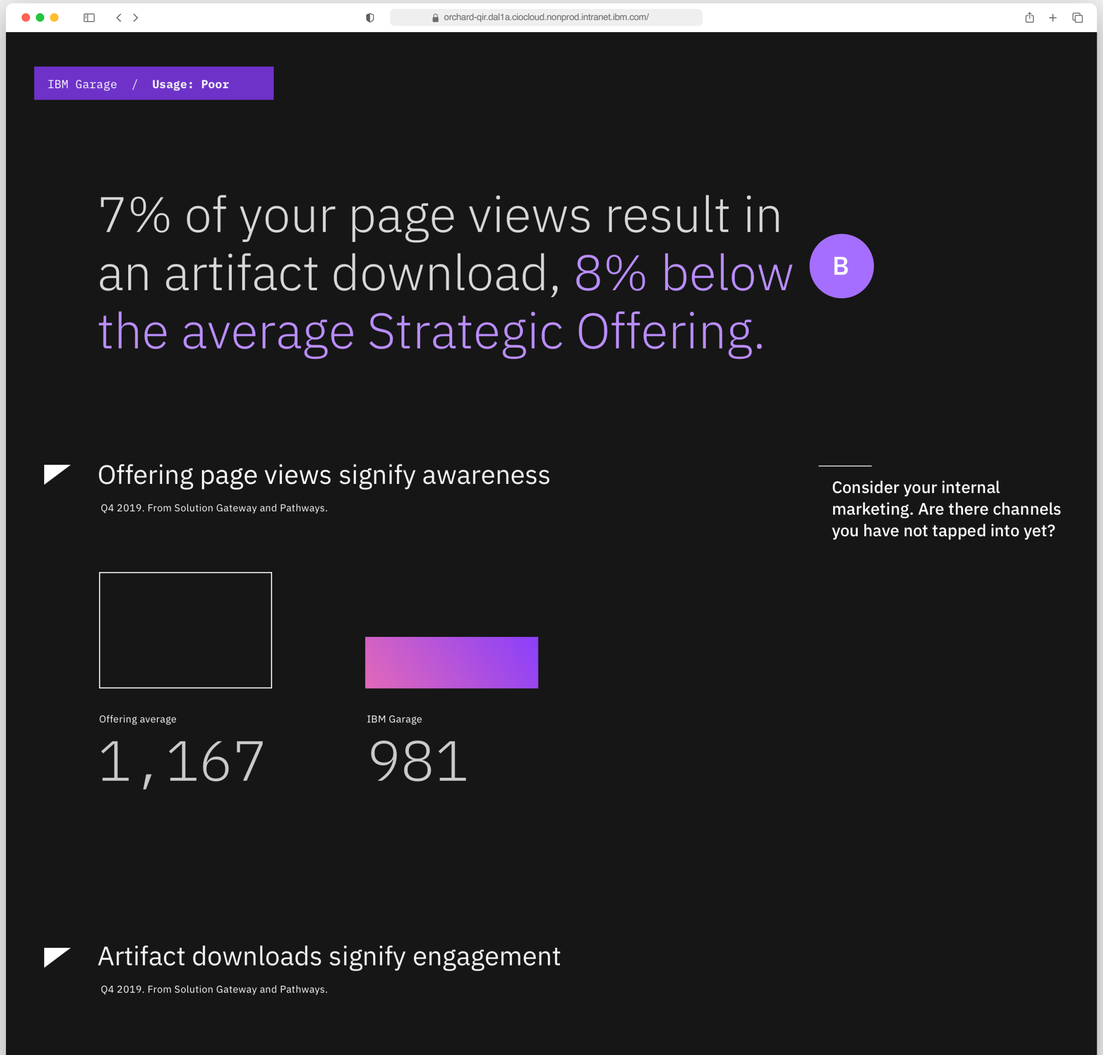
Design Decision

I used scoring to bring context to data and peer benchmarking to drive behavior change.

Scoring on landing page (A)

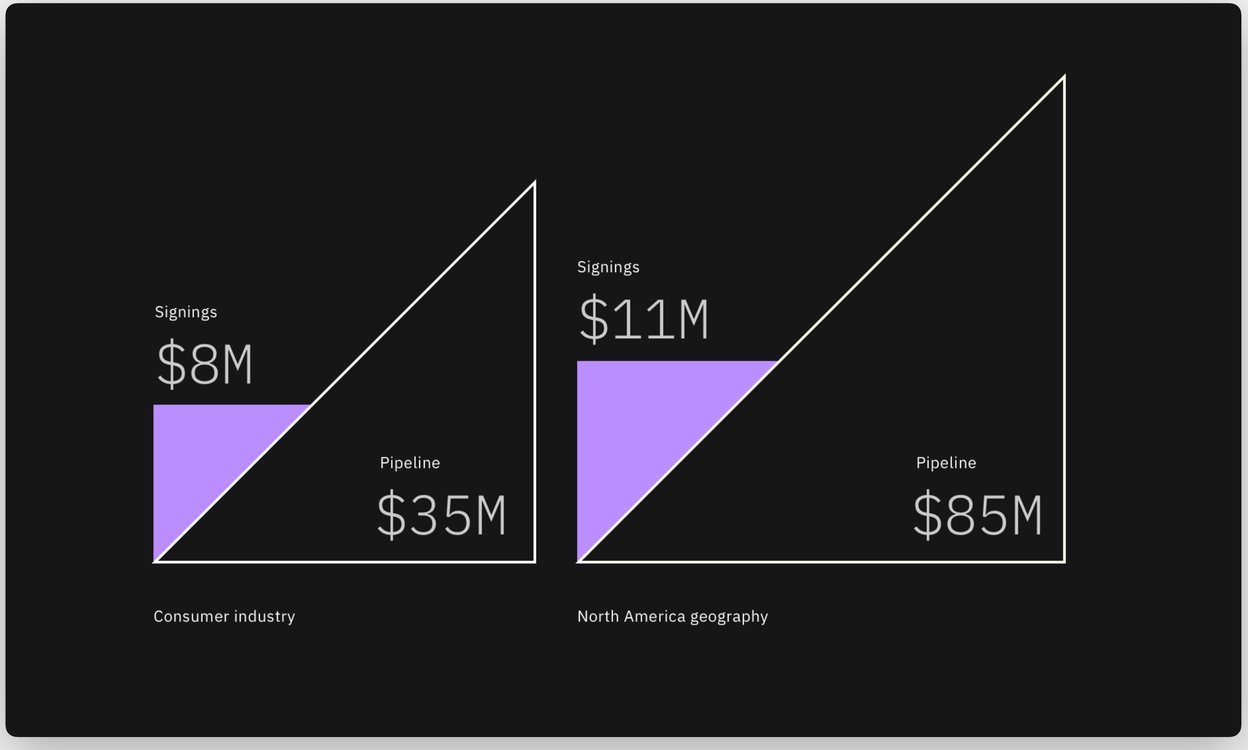


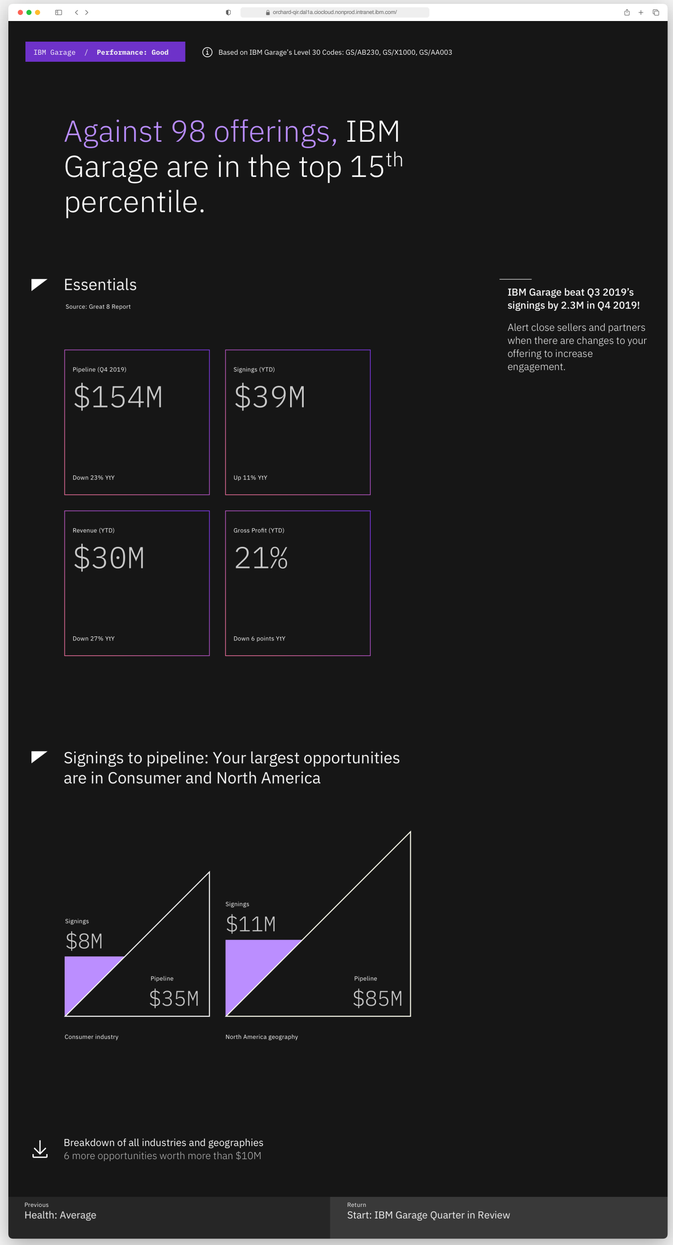
Benchmarking on Usage page (B)



Design Decision

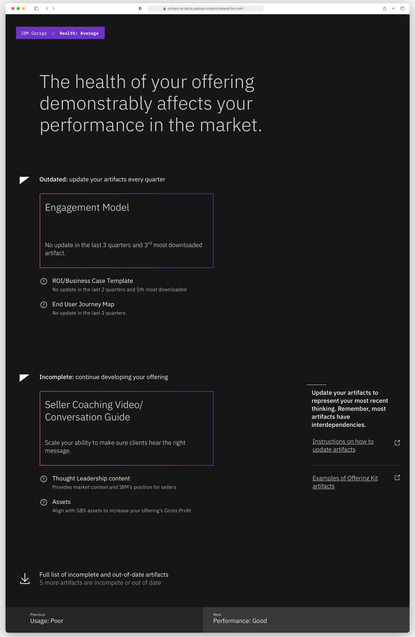
The report's executive-level audience drove the data density to be light and data visualizations to be concise and impactful.

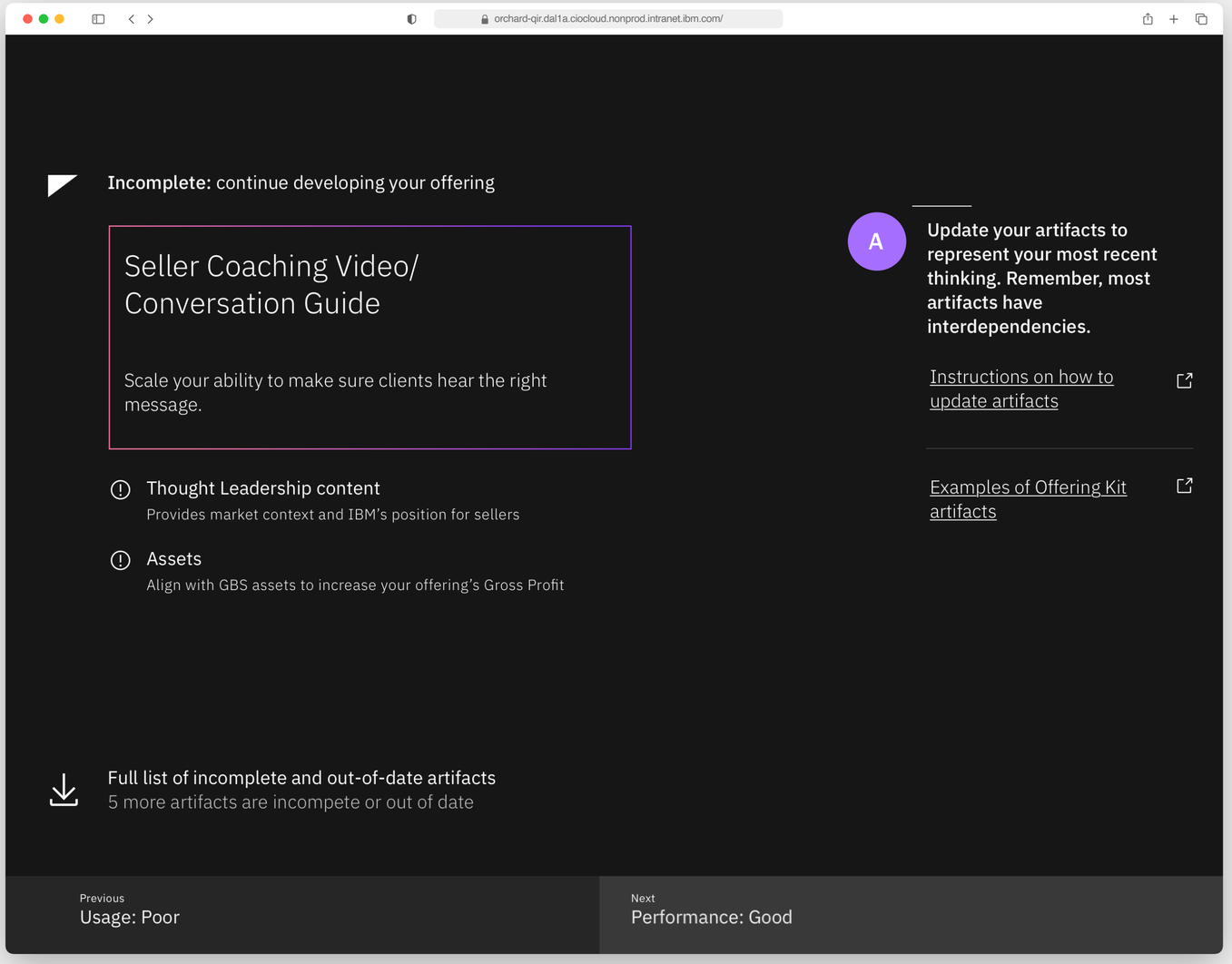




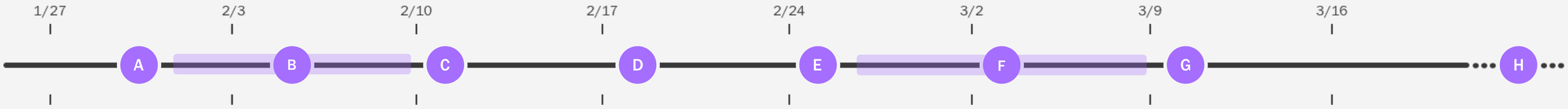
Design Decision

I scaled the voice of Offering Management and pushed teams towards lifecycle activities by providing next best steps (A).





Quarter in Review timeline
6 weeks, Q1 2020



(A) Project briefing
My design manager briefed me on the project assigned me with another designer.

(B) Problem and solution framing
My partner and I established hypotheses, user assumptions, and then designed a high-level user flow.

(C) Playback: Getting the data story right
We shared a mid-fidelity prototype that gained us alignment and elicited feedback on the narrative we made with data.

(D) Playback: Refining our vision
We presented refined data visualizations and content.

(E) Playback: Influencing the stakeholder
I influenced our stakeholder to adopt design decisions like benchmarking data and limiting the depth of information.

(F) Delivery Playbacks
I brought the report into a high-fidelity prototype and aligned with development and branding.

(G) Quarter in Review launches
The pilot report launched to 4 offerings.

(H) Quarter in Review scales past pilot
The report expanded to 28 offerings within 2 quarters and evolved into a reporting experience in a new CMS.

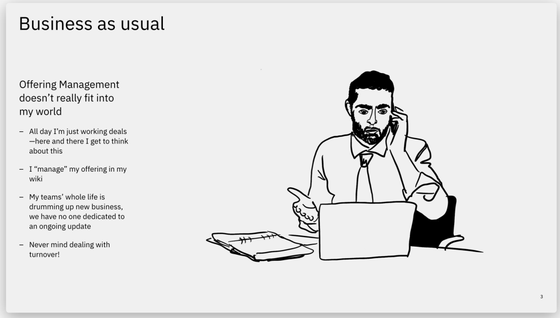
Clear goals, user research, and resources afforded us an experimentation mindset

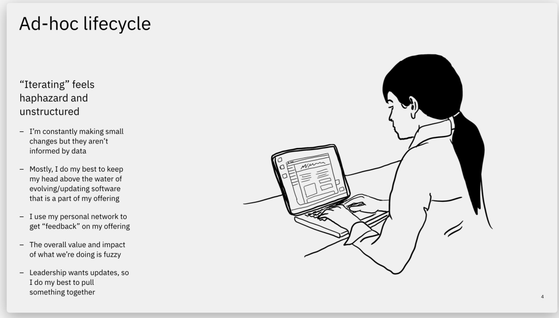
Before this project began, we rooted ourselves in the broader challenge for our design organization. I spent time exploring concepts that would push offering leaders to continuously improve their offering (A).

We came into the project with a strong understanding of users (B), a short window of opportunity, and a design system. These conditions influenced us to head quickly into prototyping.

The report was a pilot and relatively inexpensive to create. Our plan was to release it to 4 offerings and validate our assumptions. If it was success, we would scale it.

Therefore, we began with a hypothesis: We believed that if we could provide offering leaders targeted feedback on their offering, they would take the time to iterate on it.





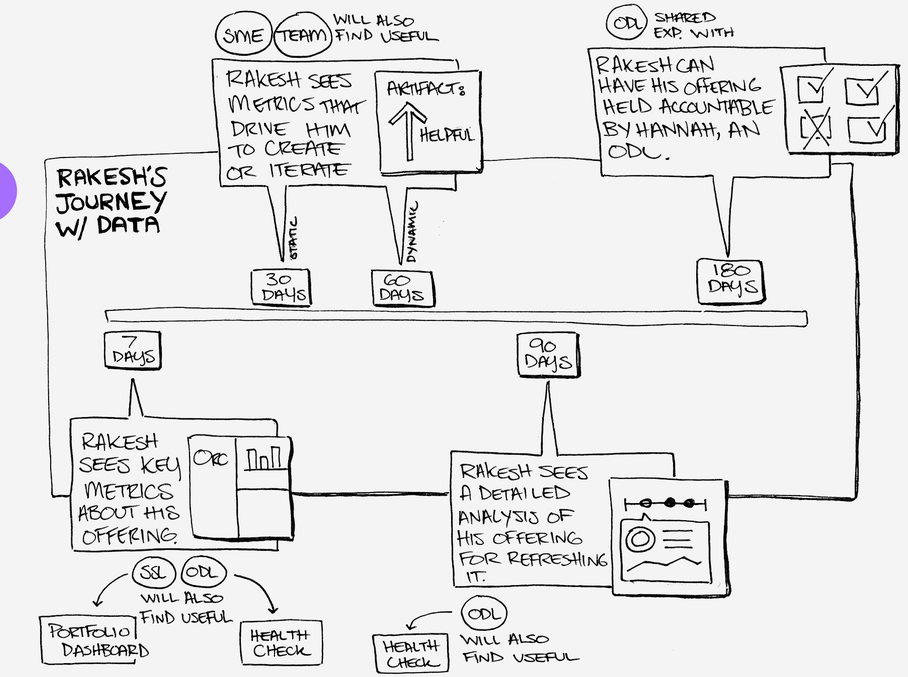


A body of research to work from

These slides show framing research I used that others performed on my design team.

B

A



Service blueprint sketch

This diagram shows how I took our design organization's vision and broke it down into a series of experiences we could deliver.

We developed hypotheses and built a user flow from available data simultaneously

First, my partner and I spent time developing a learning and research plan (A). We would use this document to help us communicate with our stakeholder, guide our design decisions while making the report, and measure the success of the report once we released it.

At this time we also brought into focus all the data that was available for us to report with. Then we began to piece together how we could make a reporting experience (B).

We made decisions about how to organize the report, how a user flows through it, how to combine or not combine metrics, which of those were most important to show, and ways we could nudge our users to make improvements on their offering.

A

Problem statement

An offering leader, who feels crushed by their workload, needs to continually update their offering, but lacks information, time, or skills to do so.

Hypothesis

We believe that by providing offering leaders high-level and pertinent information on an offering

For offering leaders

Will help them maintain and evolve higher quality offerings.

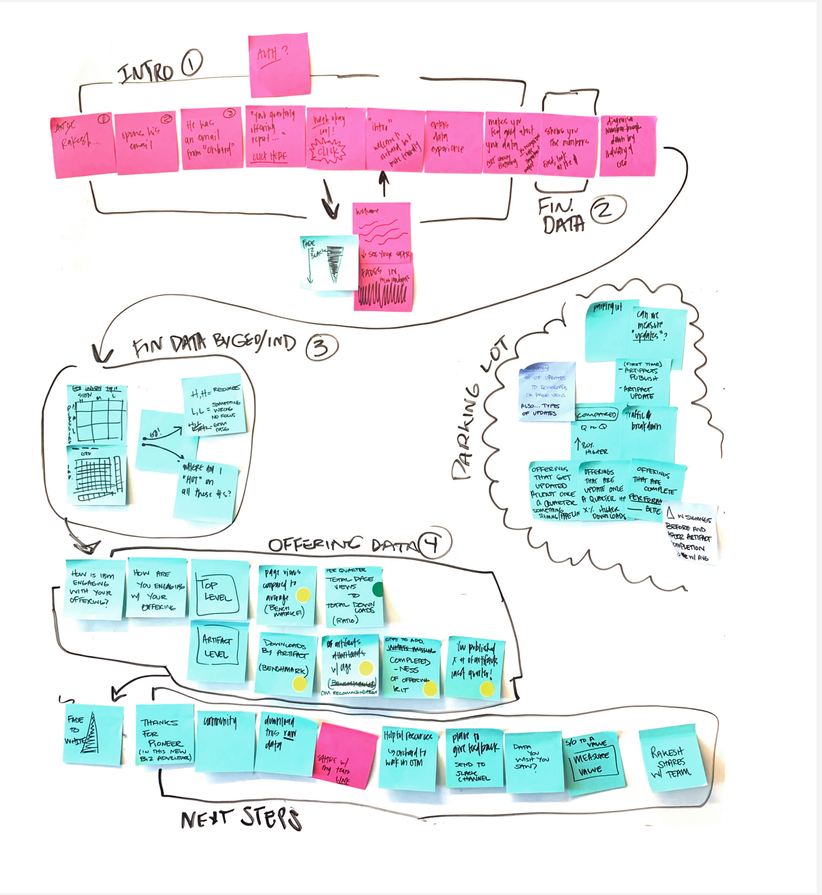
We will be successful when offering leaders share the report with their peers or team

Key assumptions

1. Offering leaders don't access to usage or health information about their offering.
2. Offering leaders don't have enough time and/or aren't willing to dedicate the time to work on their offering.
3. Offering leaders don't have the skills to analyze the data and know they should do next.

A snippet from the research plan
This is one of several assumptions we documented in our research plan.

B



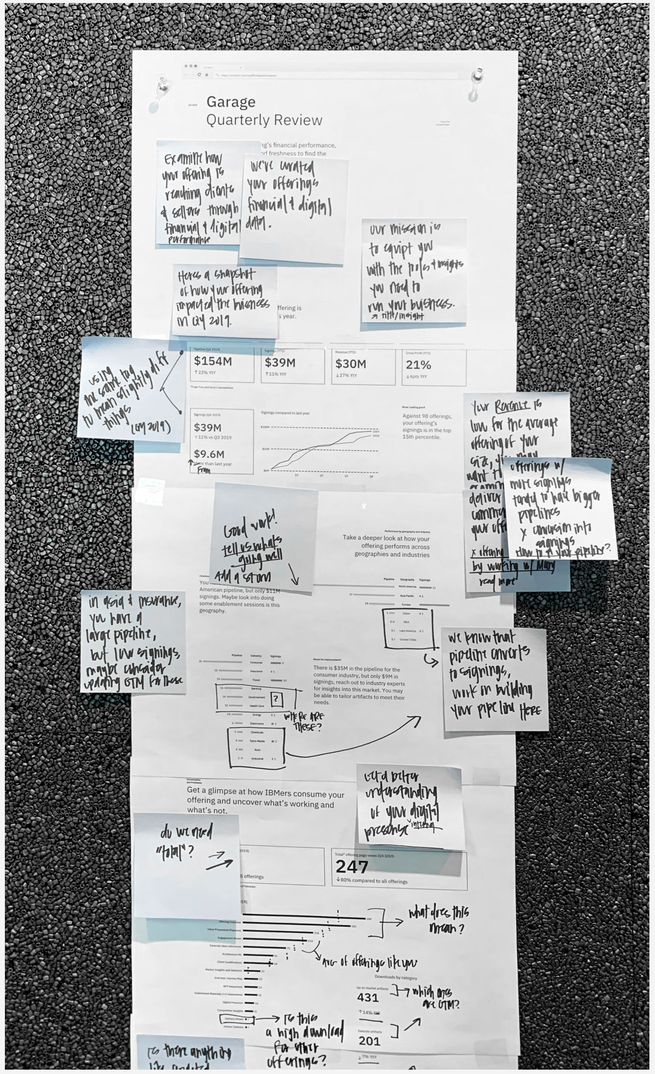
As the report's structure took shape, we avoided scaling design decisions

We developed ideas by prototyping daily and playing them back to our stakeholder each week. Sometimes these were informal wall critiques and other times formal playbacks.

We reasoned we could group content into three logical sections: usage, health, and performance. But the more elusive task was balancing stakeholder and user needs.

On one end, we believed offering leaders would adopt a simple narrative. On the other, Offering Management wanted to push teams towards lifecycle activities.

We successfully convinced our stakeholder to limit information and curtail recommendations. We explained how we could use progressive disclosure and use the first release to make adjustments for future releases (A).



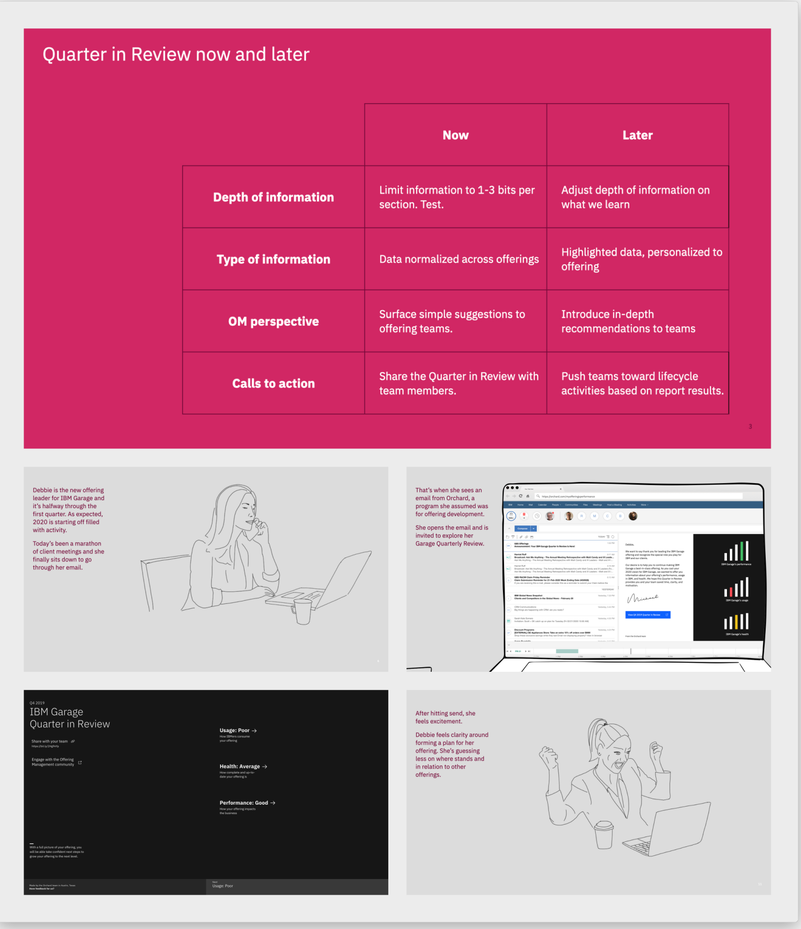
Prototyping every day

In the mornings we spent time working critiquing prototypes together, in the afternoon we mended items and build on our idea.

A

Quarter in Review now and later

	Now	Later
Depth of information	Limit information to 1-3 bits per section. Test.	Adjust depth of information on what we learn
Type of information	Data normalized across offerings	Highlighted data, personalized to offering
OM perspective	Surface simple suggestions to offering teams.	Introduce in-depth recommendations to teams
Calls to action	Share the Quarter in Review with team members.	Push teams toward lifecycle activities based on report results.



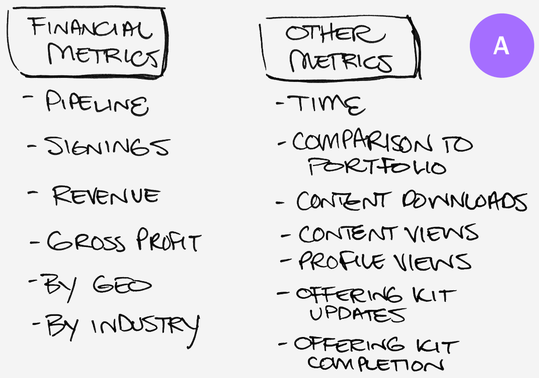
Selected slides from a playback

I honed in on a story that resonated with users and made it attention-grabbing

The organizational context that challenged our ability to hold an offering leader's attention influenced how I thought about the story we could tell them. With a variety of metrics to work with (A), I explored bringing together different metrics into "vignettes" and tested to see how each resonated with users.

Testing revealed which metrics and vignettes were most valuable. One vignette offering leaders gravitated toward showed which industries and geographies had large pipeline to signings ratios.

As the report evolved through multiple iterations, I honed in on creating story that was succinct and attention-grabbing. A prime example of this comes from the visualization depicting the pipeline to signings ratio for industries and geographies (B).





First a stacked bar chart

Bar charts were appropriate, but were used elsewhere in the report. If used repeatedly, users might coast through the report.

Then a butterfly chart

A butterfly chart could highlight the highest ratios and break up repetitiveness, but fumbled at giving users a single take away.

Then a proportional area chart

Showing only the largest ratio made the message succinct. And, this chart had a "big animal picture" quality that commanded attention.

Lastly a new proportional area chart

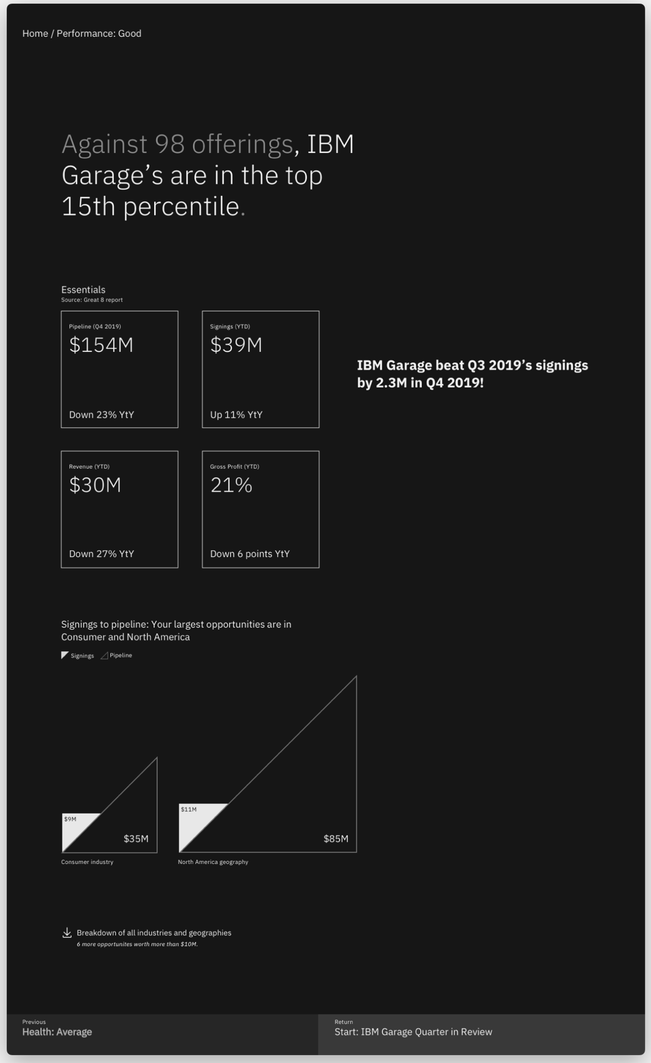
Triangles are cautionary. Stacking them added a sense of play, tempting one to grow the signings triangle past the pipeline triangle.

I abstained from finalizing visual design so another designer could apply new branding.

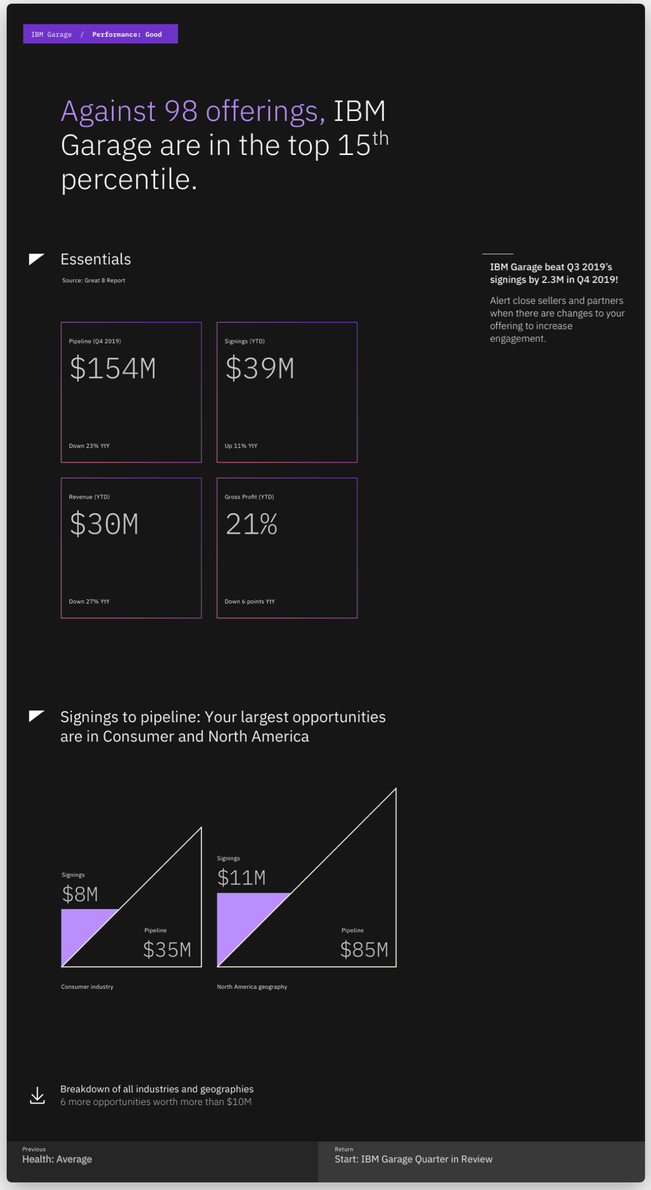
I took lead on visual design and defined the layout, spacing, form, and typography for the report.

Concurrently, a visual designer was reworking Offering Management's brand. I refrained from finalizing the visual design (A). Before the report's release, she applied branding (B).

A



B



“I am thrilled to see a report of this nature, every quarter. It not only helps me to assess the progress made, it also helps to focus on area of improvements.”

—IBM Services Offering Leader

After we released the report, we saw engagement and praise from our users

After 6 weeks from design to development, we released the Quarter in Review to four offering teams as a pilot. Then we collected data and observed several signs of success:

- 76% of users returned within the week
- 44% of users downloaded the full report
- 60% engagement rate in the first week with unique users clicking on the link from our email

Besides metrics signifying engagement with our users, we received a steady pour of praise for the report. A pattern we heard was the report made their lives easier and their roles feel supported by the business.

The Quarter in Review built trust with our stakeholders and scaled to more offerings

Pitching this win under our belt demonstrated to our stakeholders in Offering Management that we could drive their mission forward with a design-led approach. They approved to the report to scale:

- The second release scaled to 11 Offerings (June 2020)
- The third release scaled to 28 Offerings (August 2020)

The Quarter in review paved the way for Content+’s reporting experience

As the report was on a trajectory to continue scaling, I integrated many elements of the Quarter in Review into a reporting experience for an emerging content management system called Content+.

My message to clients: invest in design systems and user knowledge domains

Businesses can take the edge off innovation with an exploratory approach

Businesses tend to be risk averse and rightfully so. It's costly, even devastating, to miscalculate the market. But equally harmful is not getting to the market fast enough, if at all.

The anxiety to take the plunge or not is intense, but it doesn't have to be. With the right pieces in play, the cost of innovation can fall to a point where it can make more sense to prioritize risk over safety.

This doesn't mean throwing caution to the wind. It means that when a business quickly and cheaply releases an experiment, they can look before they leap. All the while avoiding expensive cycles on feasibility studies and research.

Past user research and our design system enabled us to release the report efficiently

All parts of an organization must have certain adjustments to make this approach successful. As for the design organization, I have witnessed two conditions that have enabled us to help the business cheaply and quickly release experiments and learn before scaling up: design systems and user knowledge domains.

The Quarter in Review is an excellent example of how these came together.

Design systems bring ideas to life with little friction and unlocks creativity

I used the Carbon Design System to accelerate my ability to bring ideas into high-fidelity that could translate into code with little friction.

But this efficiency did more than speed up design. It opened up the project to benefit from strong visual and user experience design. I used the time freed to reinvest back into the data visualizations to make them more distinct and powerful.

The pipeline to signings chart demonstrates how I was able to develop an innovative data visualization that went beyond the standards of the design system and closely targeted our users.

User knowledge domains bootstrap designers and are mindfully constructed

Having a user knowledge domain helped me design the report efficiently because I was able to easily orient myself in the problem space and make more informed design decisions.

The impact came from how my design organization wielded knowledge about offering leaders. There was continuity. Every project we took on had a research component and learnings always factored into the next opportunity. And they were documented and stored on our file repository. User knowledge was accessible, no matter how much the team's availability waxed and waned.